A NEW LIFE OPERATING SYSTEM · VISION DOCUMENT · V6

BU v6
The Fire

A discipline-first life system. It watches, it remembers, it speaks the truth. The fire is alive — keep it lit.

“Open the app. See the fire. Tap it. Get the one play that matters. Go do it. The fire grows. Drift, and the fire dims. The app goes dark. You want it back — tend it.”



PREPARED FOR
Dhivakaran · Galaxy A54 · November 2026

SUPERSEDES
BU v1 build guide · v2 parts 1–7 · v3 LOOM/BTK · v4 locked plan · v5 the garden (killed)

STATUS

Vision document. Build plan and GitHub repo initialization to follow.

§ 1 · THE BEGINNING

The One Paragraph

> *"BU is a fire. You tend it or it dies. The app watches you honestly, remembers everything, speaks the truth in one sentence, and withholds its own value when you drift. The fire is the discipline."*

You killed the garden. Right call — it was a skin. You wanted discipline, real discipline, with an app that watches you and pushes you hard. You wanted something a free app will never give for free: on-device AI, system-level awareness, complete life logging, and a fire that grows over years of being true to yourself. This is that app. The metaphor is now a fire — not decorative, not gamified, but the literal functional state of the app. When the fire is lit, BU is sharp, present, watching with you. When the fire is dead, BU goes dark and silent. You want it back? Tend it.

This document locks the v6 concept. It is built for a one-year, 2-hours-a-day build cycle on a public GitHub repository with a memory folder any LLM can read. The end state is a never-before product: a discipline OS that watches you at the system level, remembers everything, computes the single highest-leverage play for your day, intervenes when you drift with smart context-awareness, and renders your discipline as a fire that grows over months and years — never ending, like Egg, Inc, but for your real life.

THE SHAPE OF THIS DOCUMENT

Part I (§ 2) is the architectural breakthrough — the two-tier product (Lite and Full). Part II (§ 3–4) is the soul and the eyes — the Fire and the Watcher. Part III (§ 5–6) is the brain and the discipline — the Forge and the Play. Part IV (§ 7–8) is the push and the reflection — the intervention ladder with smart context, and the three-surface journaling. Part V (§ 9–10) is the record and the rhythm — the Life Log (auto + manual) and the daily/weekly cycle. Part VI (§ 11–12) is the architecture and the look — five layers, and the fire's multi-year growth animation. Part VII (§ 13–14) is the moat, the build plan, and the GitHub repository structure. The appendix is the full v4 → v5 → v6 concept lineage.

THE EIGHT THINGS THAT CHANGED FROM v5

Two-tier architecture. BU Lite = plan/execute/focus/journal, no model, no Watcher. BU Full = user opts in → app downloads Gemma 3 1B → Watcher activates → the Forge intelligence kicks in. The model download is a commitment moment, not silent bloat.

The Fire replaces the Bloom. A fire demands fuel or it dies. Gardens tolerate neglect; fires do not. The fire is the literal functional state of the app — lit, the app is sharp; dead, the app goes dark. This is the discipline pressure no ring or streak can match.

The Watcher is full power. Foreground service + UsageStats polling every 30s + Notification Listener + AccessibilityService (for drift detection). Persistent notification required. ~3–5%

battery/day cost. The user consents at first open.

The Forge is real on-device AI. Gemma 3 1B (529MB int4) as the router, Qwen 0.6B for structured tool calls, ObjectBox 4.0 with HNSW vector index for memory. RAG over your own embers. Pattern detection, prediction, causal chains.

Intervention escalates with smart context. 20 min drift → soft nudge. 30 min → aggressive nudge. 60 min → overlay + 30-min block. BUT: AccessibilityService reads the YouTube video title → Forge classifies educational vs not → if educational and user confirms → no punishment. The hardest engineering piece in v1.

Journaling has three surfaces. Write (blank page), Voice (Whisper-tiny on-device, 30 sec max), Free-draw (Excalidraw-style canvas). All three become embers the Forge can reference.

The Life Log is auto + manual. Watcher logs phone activity in detail. For off-phone time, user adds title + description + duration. Over time this becomes a complete record of your life — phone activity auto, off-phone activity manual. You can see your life back, in detail, years later.

The Fire grows over years. Not a static UI element. Procedural fire animation that grows day-by-day, week-by-week, month-by-month, year-by-year. 30 days of being true to yourself (no cheating the app — photo proof gates this) = the “gorgeous” final stage. Then it keeps growing into new stages. Never ending, like Egg, Inc, but earned through real discipline.

§ 2 · THE ARCHITECTURAL BREAKTHROUGH

The Two-Tier Product

The biggest decision in v6 is that BU ships in two tiers, and the user chooses when to cross over. This is not a freemium paywall — both tiers are free, both are local, both are private. The tier boundary is the model download. It exists because the model is 529MB and the Watcher is a persistent foreground service — both are real costs, and the user should consent to them deliberately, not have them silently imposed.

BU LITE — the planning app

Works without the model, without the Watcher. Pure planning and execution surface: plan tomorrow, plan next week, run focus sessions (Normal and Hard), journal in three surfaces, see your day's log. The fire is dim by default in Lite — you can tend it manually (mark a play done), but the app cannot see whether you actually did anything. Lite is honest about what it is: a planning tool, not a discipline engine.

BU FULL — the discipline engine

When the user opts in (a single toggle in settings, or a "Light the fire" moment after onboarding), the app prompts: *"Download the local model (529MB)? This activates the Watcher — a persistent service that sees what apps you use and when. Everything stays on your device."* On confirm, the model downloads, the Watcher activates, and the Forge intelligence comes alive. Now the fire is honest — it dims when you drift, brightens when you tend. The Play is computed, not written. Patterns surface. Predictions appear. The Life Log fills automatically.

> **WHY TWO TIERS**
>
> Three reasons. (1) Friction: a 529MB silent download on first open is hostile. (2) Consent: the Watcher is a system-level service that sees everything you do — the user must choose it. (3) Honesty: if the user does not care enough to opt in, they get nothing — which is exactly the discipline pressure the app is built to apply. Free apps chase you. BU waits.

A user can stay in Lite forever. They get a clean plan-and-execute app with focus sessions and journaling. The fire is cosmetic. That is fine. The product is honest about what Lite is. Most users who install BU and don't opt in will leave — and that is the point. The product is for people who want to be watched and pushed. Everyone else has 100 other planning apps.

§ 3 · THE SOUL

The Fire

A fire is the right metaphor for a discipline system because it has three honest properties no other metaphor has. First, a fire needs fuel or it dies — you cannot “tend a garden,” gardens tolerate neglect; a fire demands fuel or it goes out, and the visual feedback is honest in a way no ring or streak can be. Second, a fire can be rebuilt, but it takes effort — unlike a broken streak (Duolingo shame), a dead fire can be relit, but you have to choose to relight it, and the rebuild is harder than maintaining. Third, a fire gives light and warmth when alive — when the fire is burning, the app is useful; when it is dead, the app goes dark and silent. The app withholds its own value when you neglect it. Free apps chase you with notifications. BU goes dark. You want it back? Tend it.

THE FIVE FIRE STATES

The fire has five visual states, computed from the last 7 days of evidence-graded behavior. The state is the verdict. There is no number, no percentage — the fire is the metric.

BLAZING · Solid, bright, full. You are becoming who you said you would be. The Forge is sharp, present, watching with you.

BURNING · Steady, warm. You are holding course. The Forge is active.

FLICKERING · Slight wobble, dimmer. You are slipping, slowly. The Forge notes it, says nothing yet.

EMBERS · Dim, half-empty. You have stopped. The Forge goes quiet — one line at evening: “the fire is low.”

OUT · Dark, thin. You are losing ground. The app is nearly silent. To relight: tap the fire, do the play, repeat for 3 days.

THE GORGEOUS STATE — 30 DAYS OF TRUTH

Above Blazing is one more state, earned only through 30 consecutive days of being true to yourself. “True to yourself” means: no cheating the app. The Forge cross-checks every tending against passive proof (did the Watcher see you open the study app for ≥20 min?), time proof (did the play timer run?), photo proof (did you snap a photo whose embedding is sufficiently novel?), and outcome proof (did a measurable result come later?). Tendings that fail these checks do not count toward the 30 days. The Gorgeous state is not cosmetic — it is the visual rendering of an honest 30-day streak of real discipline.

THE MULTI-YEAR GROWTH ARC

The fire does not stop at Gorgeous. Like Egg, Inc, the fire is a never-ending growth animation. Day by day, the flame tongues refine. Week by week, new visual elements appear (a second flame, a halo, embers floating up). Month by month, the fire’s base widens. Year by year, entirely new stages unlock — the fire becomes a hearth, then a forge, then a constellation. Every stage maps to a real behavioral

milestone, not a cosmetic one. The animation system is procedural (not hand-drawn stages) because hand-animating 50 stages is infeasible for one developer at 2 hours a day. Procedural fire + milestone-driven state changes is the only path to “never ending.”

> **WHY THIS HAS NOT BEEN SHIPPED**
>
> Every fire/streak app I found either makes the fire decorative (Forest — tree grows, you do not really lose it) or shames you when it dies (Habitica — you lose HP). BU’s fire is the actual functional state of the app — when the fire is low, the app’s intelligence dims, surfaces less, goes quiet. When the fire is high, the app is sharp, present, watching with you. The fire is the engagement economy, inverted. Nobody does this because inverting engagement is bad business — unless your business is the user’s actual discipline, not their attention.

§ 4 · THE EYES

The Watcher

The Watcher is what makes BU Full different from every other discipline app. It is a system-level observer that runs as a persistent foreground service and sees, in real time, what you do on your phone. It is not optional in Full mode — without the Watcher, the Forge cannot compute an honest fire state, cannot detect drift, cannot fill the Life Log automatically. The Watcher is the cost of admission for the discipline engine.

WHAT THE WATCHER SEES

App foreground events. Every app you open, every switch, every close. Source: UsageStatsManager (MOVE_TO_FOREGROUND events). Polled every 30 seconds.

Session durations. How long each app was foregrounded. Computed from the event state machine (Android gives raw events, not sessions — you build the session math yourself).

Screen on/off. When the screen is on, when it is off. Sleep proxy = longest screen-off stretch in 24h.

Unlocks. How many times you unlocked the phone. KEYGUARD_HIDDEN events.

Notifications. What apps notified you, when, how often. Source: NotificationListenerService (opt-in, separate permission). Content is NOT read — only the source app and timestamp.

Active play window. When a focus session is sealed, the Watcher knows the play is active and watches for drift specifically during that window.

Accessibility events (optional, opt-in). For drift context: when you drift into YouTube during a study play, the AccessibilityService reads only the video title (not the page, not your data) and passes it to the Forge for educational classification. This is the most permission-sensitive part and is gated behind a separate explicit consent.

THE PERSISTENT NOTIFICATION COST

Android 14+ requires that any foreground service shows a persistent notification. There is no way around this — every screen-time app (Mindful, Opal, one sec) shows one. BU's notification will be honest: *"BU is watching. The fire is burning."* It updates with the fire state. When the fire is out, the notification reads *"BU is waiting. Tap to relight."* The notification is the cost of the discipline engine. Users who do not want it stay in Lite.

BATTERY AND PERFORMANCE

Full power means ~3–5% battery per day on a Galaxy A54. The poll-every-30s UsageStats pattern is well-trodden and within Android's limits. The Gemma 3 1B model is loaded lazily — only when the Forge needs to compute (drift classification, daily play choice, Sunday review). The Watcher itself is pure Kotlin, no model — it just logs events. The model wakes on demand and evicts on memory pressure.

ANDROID REALITIES — CONFIRMED FROM RESEARCH

UsageStatsManager gives raw events, no helper methods — you build the session state machine yourself. Background service limits (Android 8+) require a Foreground Service for any persistent watching. AccessibilityService for content reading is fragile (apps update their UI, your selectors break) and Google Play scrutinizes its use — it must be optional, separately consented, and clearly disclosed. All of these are solved problems with known trade-offs, not blockers.

§ 5 · THE BRAIN

The Forge

The Forge is the on-device intelligence layer. It is what turns the Watcher's raw events into the Fire state, the daily Play, the patterns, the predictions, and the drift interventions. The Forge is the reason BU Full exists as a separate tier — without the local model, none of this is possible.

THE MODEL STACK

Gemma 3 1B (int4, 529MB) — the router. Handles intent classification, daily play choice, journal entry summarization, promise extraction. Runs on MediaPipe LLM Inference API with NPU acceleration where available. Confirmed: 2585 tok/s prefill on mobile, fits comfortably in 6GB RAM.

Qwen 2.5 0.6B (quantized) — the structured tool caller. When the user writes "remind me to call Aisha Friday," Qwen outputs clean JSON the app can act on. Gemma is the conversationalist; Qwen is the JSON factory. Both load lazily.

Gemini Nano (if present) — the fast path. On Pixel 8 Pro / S24+ / 2026 flagships, AICore gives zero-overhead inference. Detected at runtime; if present, used for low-latency tasks (drift classification, smart replies). If absent (most devices including Galaxy A54), Gemma 3 1B handles everything. The fallback architecture is Gemma-first, Nano-optional.

THE MEMORY — OBJECTBOX + HNSW

The Forge does not keep memory in the model's context window. That would crash the RAM. Instead, every action, every journal entry, every drift event, every play outcome is embedded (via Gemma's embedding head or MobileNet for images) and stored as a vector in **ObjectBox 4.0** with an **HNSW index**. ObjectBox is the first on-device vector database for Android, with millisecond similarity search across millions of vectors. When the Forge needs context ("what does this user do on Thursdays?"), it embeds the query and retrieves the top-K relevant embers. RAG, but local, private, and offline.

WHAT THE FORGE COMPUTES

The Fire state. A 7-day rolling verdict computed from evidence-graded behavior. Not a number — a state (Blazing / Burning / Flickering / Embers / Out / Gorgeous).

The daily Play. One sentence: the single highest-leverage action for today, computed from your trajectory. "Calculus II. 45 min. Before noon." Tap to start, tap to done.

Pattern detection. "You skip study every Thursday. You miss after sleeping under 6h. You nail it when the deadline is <3 days out." Surfaced at Sunday Review.

Prediction. "34% chance you do this tomorrow. Here's what raises it to 71%: start before noon." Surfaced when you tap the fire.

Causal chains. "When you tend Calculus in the morning, you tend Aisha that evening 78% of the time. The morning play matters more than you think." Surfaced only when confidence is high.

Identity streaks. Never as a number, always as a statement: “You’ve shown up 4 of last 7 days. That’s who you are now.” Not “don’t break the chain” — “this is becoming you.”

Promise extraction. From journal entries: “I’ll call Aisha Friday” → confirm chip → reminder created. Confidence-routed: high → act, medium → confirm, low → ignore.

Drift classification. When the Watcher detects YouTube during a study play, the Forge reads the video title (via AccessibilityService) and classifies educational vs not. Educational + user confirm → no punishment.

Photo proof verification. MobileNet v3 (1.8MB) embeds your proof photo into a 1280-dim vector. Compared to historical embeddings — if sufficiently novel (not yesterday’s photo), the tending is marked OUTCOME_CONFIRMED. The raw photo is deleted after embedding.

§ 6 · THE DISCIPLINE

The Play

When you tap the fire ring, one sentence reveals. That is the Play. Not a list, not a card with alternatives, not a probability breakdown — one sentence, sharp, coach-style. The discipline is in the singularity: you cannot negotiate with a list of one.

LITE — YOU WRITE THE PLAY

In BU Lite, the Play is yours. Each evening (or morning), you write one sentence: the single thing that, if done, makes today a success. The app holds you to it — at evening close, you face the question: did you do it? You can write a different play every day, or reuse one. The Lite Play is honest about its limit: the app cannot see whether you did it, only whether you say you did. The fire in Lite is dim because the discipline is on you.

FULL — THE FORGE CHOOSES THE PLAY

In BU Full, the Forge computes the Play from your trajectory. It reads your embers (when did you last tend Calculus? when is the midterm? did you sleep 5h?), runs the chooser, and proposes one sentence. You can swap (the Forge learns from your swap), but you never face a blank list. The Play is sharp, specific, and earned from your own history.

EXAMPLE PLAYS

> *"“Calculus II. 45 minutes. Before noon. That’s the play.”"*
> Standard play — subject, duration, time window.

> *"“You said you’d call Aisha. It’s been 23 days. Make the call.”"*
> Relational play — Bird neglect detected.

> *"“You slept 5h 12m last night. Today’s play is small: 15 min of Organic Chemistry. That’s it.”"*
> Low-energy play — sleep proxy detected, expectations calibrated down. No shame.

> *"“Midterm in 9 days. Today: chapter 7 problem set. Before you do anything else.”"*
> Season-urgency play — harvest proximity drives priority.

> *"“You skipped study every Thursday for 6 weeks. Today, break the pattern. 20 minutes.”"*
> Pattern-driven play — causal detection surfaces the cycle.

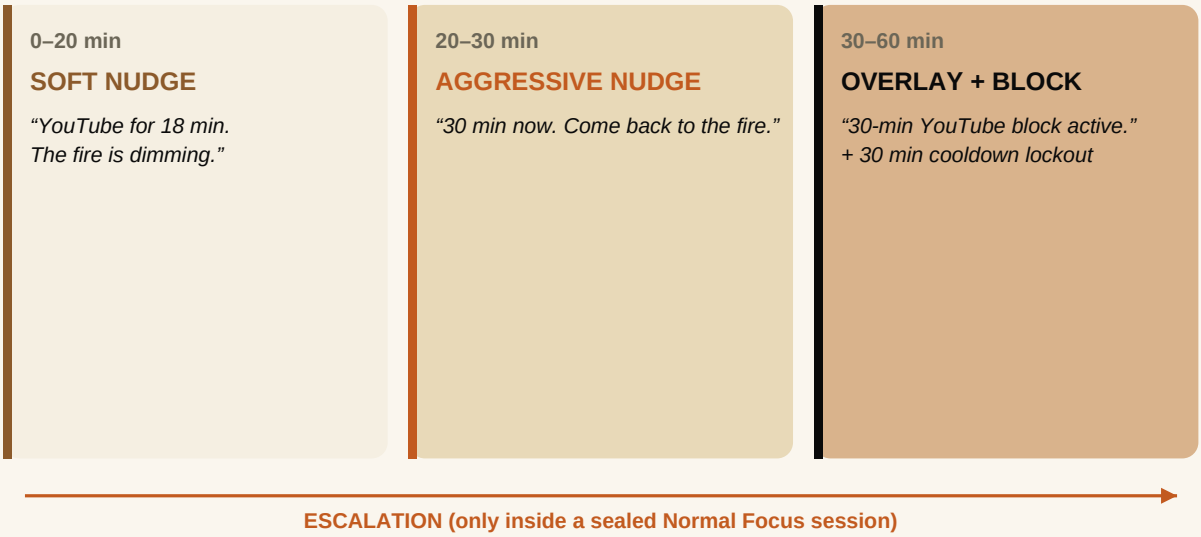
WHY ONE SENTENCE

A list of 5 tasks lets you negotiate. A calendar lets you defer. A priority matrix lets you re-rank forever. One sentence does not negotiate. You do it or you do not. The Forge has done the work of choosing — your only job is to execute. This is the discipline.

§ 7 · THE PUSH

The Intervention Ladder + Focus Modes

When the Watcher detects drift (you open YouTube during a sealed study Play), BU intervenes. The intervention escalates in three stages. The escalation only happens inside a sealed Normal Focus session — outside focus, you can do whatever you want. The app is not your parent; it only pushes during the windows you sealed.



SMART CONTEXT — THE EDUCATIONAL EXCEPTION

The hardest engineering piece in v1: not all YouTube is drift. If you are watching a calculus lecture during a study play, that is study. The Forge needs to know. The flow: when YouTube opens during a Normal Focus play, the AccessibilityService reads only the video title (not the page, not your data — the title is enough). The title is passed to Gemma 3 1B, which classifies it against your current Play subject. If classified as educational and confidence is high, a confirm chip appears: *"Looks like you're studying. Continue without intervention?"* Tap yes → no escalation. Tap no → standard ladder. If confidence is low or classification is non-educational, standard ladder.

ACCESSIBILITY SERVICE — HONEST RISK

AccessibilityService is fragile (YouTube updates its UI, your view-ID selectors break) and Google Play scrutinizes its use. Mitigations: (1) ship the intervention ladder WITHOUT smart-context first (P3 of the build plan); (2) add Accessibility in P4 only after the base system works; (3) keep the title-reading selectors in an updatable rules file so a YT UI change does not require an app update; (4) clearly disclose to the user and to Google Play what the service does and why. This is marked experimental and may be removed if Play policy changes.

FOCUS MODES

Normal Focus. The default. You seal a play (e.g., “Calculus II, 45 min”). The Watcher watches for drift. The intervention ladder activates if you drift. Educational YouTube is exempt via smart context. Everything else is allowed — you can check messages, take calls, look things up. Normal Focus trusts you with friction.

Hard Focus. The nuclear option. You choose a whitelist (calls + 2–3 apps you genuinely need, e.g., Anki, calculator, banking). Everything else is blocked for the duration of the focus session. The block is enforced via an overlay (AccessibilityService) or local VPN (cutting internet per-app, Mindful-style). Hard Focus does not trust you with friction — it removes the option. Use it for the 2 hours before an exam, not for daily study.

§ 8 · THE REFLECTION

Journaling — Three Surfaces

No garden, no Stones. Writing lives in three places, all one swipe away from the fire ring. The Forge reads every entry on-device (Gemma 3 1B) and uses it: extracts promises, links to embers, surfaces old entries at Sunday Review. Your reflection is data, not archive.

SWIPE RIGHT — THE BLANK PAGE

A clean, full-screen writing surface. No template, no prompts, no metadata. Just paper. Write what happened, what you felt, what you noticed. Autosaves. The Forge reads it overnight, extracts anything actionable, indexes it for retrieval. You can attach an entry to a Play (it becomes context for tomorrow's choice) or leave it rootless.

SWIPE LEFT — VOICE

Hold to record, 30 seconds max. Whisper-tiny transcribes on-device. Hands-free. For 3am thoughts, walking thoughts, shower thoughts — the moments when writing is too slow but speaking captures the texture. The transcription becomes an ember, same as a written entry.

SWIPE UP — FREE-DRAW CANVAS

An Excalidraw-style infinite canvas. Pen, shapes, arrows, text. For mind maps, plans, diagrams, doodles. The canvas is not decorative — what you draw becomes an ember. The Forge stores the canvas as an SVG (vector, tiny, lossless) and an embedding. Next time you study Calculus, the Forge can surface: *"You drew a mind map about integration by parts last Tuesday. Want to see it?"* The draw layer is the third journaling surface because some thinking is spatial, not linear.

> **WHY THREE SURFACES**
>
> Different thoughts fit different surfaces. A 3am anxiety is voice (writing is too slow). A weekly plan is a canvas (structure is spatial). A reflective paragraph is the blank page. Forcing all thought through one surface loses texture. Three surfaces, one Forge, one memory.

§ 9 · THE RECORD

The Life Log

You said: *"this is a thing I always wanted."* The Life Log is BU's complete record of your days — auto-captured when you are on your phone, manually filled when you are off it. Over time it becomes a high-fidelity record of your life, searchable, browsable, yours.

AUTO — PHONE ACTIVITY

The Watcher logs every app foreground event with timestamp and duration. The Life Log aggregates these into a timeline of your day: 7:14 Instagram (12 min) → 7:26 WhatsApp (4 min) → 7:30 Anki (22 min) → 7:52 YouTube (38 min, flagged as drift) → 8:30 Sleep (screen off, longest stretch). Every event is an ember. You can see your day back, in detail, the next morning or ten years later.

MANUAL — OFF-PHONE ACTIVITY

When you were off your phone (sleeping, in class, hanging out, reading a paper book), the log has a gap. BU prompts you at evening close: *"What were you doing 2pm–5pm?"* You add a title ("Organic Chemistry lab"), a description ("Titration experiment, partner was Aisha, ran long because the burette jammed"), and the time window. The entry fills the gap in your Life Log. Over time, the manual entries form a parallel record of your off-phone life — the part no app can see, but the most important part.

THE COMPLETE RECORD

Auto phone activity + manual off-phone activity = your complete day, every day. The Life Log is browsable by date (calendar view), searchable by keyword or semantic query ("what was I doing last Tuesday?"), and exportable as Markdown. The Forge uses it for pattern detection ("you skip study every Thursday") and prediction. You use it to see your life back. This is the part no free app gives you, because no free app combines system-level auto-capture with user-authored manual entries into one timeline.

> **EVIDENCE GRADES — THE GARDEN NEVER LIES, AND NEITHER DOES THE LOG**
>
> Every Life Log entry carries an evidence grade. Auto-captured phone events: OBSERVED. Manual entries: USER_CONFIRMED. Entries inferred from context (e.g., "you were probably in class because the phone was off 9am–12pm on a weekday"): INFERRED, marked as such. Outcome-confirmed entries (e.g., exam score proves the study happened): OUTCOME_CONFIRMED. The grades are visible in the log — you always know what the app saw vs what you said vs what it inferred. The log never lies, because the grades are preserved.

§ 10 · THE RHYTHM

First Open · Daily Cycle · Sunday Review

FIRST OPEN — THREE QUESTIONS

You install BU. You open it. The screen is warm cream, mostly empty. A small ember glows. The app asks three questions, one per screen, with giant type:

1. *What are you working toward?*

   Examples: “Pass Calculus II with a B.” “Get into a top-20 university for grad school.” “Become someone who keeps their word.”

2. *What pulls you off track?*

   Examples: “YouTube at night.” “Phone in bed.” “Avoiding hard problems.”

3. *What does discipline look like for you?*

   Examples: “Studying before noon.” “No phone in the bedroom.” “Showing up even when I don’t feel like it.”

These three answers become the Forge’s priors. The Forge does not ask your name (it picks it up from your phone), your age, your job, your “user type.” It asks what you are working toward, what pulls you off, and what discipline means to you. Then it shows the fire, dim, and asks: *“Light the fire?”* This is the opt-in moment for Full mode. If you say no, you are in Lite — plan and execute, no Watcher. If you say yes, the model downloads, the Watcher activates, and the fire is now honest.

THE DAILY CYCLE

Morning Spark (30 sec). You open BU. The fire shows its state. You tap. The Play reveals — one sentence. You commit. You close the app. The day begins.

Tending (the day itself). The Watcher watches. If you drift during a sealed focus session, the intervention ladder activates. If you tend the play (passive proof, time proof, photo proof), the fire brightens. The app is mostly silent — the discipline is in the watching, not the nagging.

Evening Close (60 sec). At your chosen evening time, BU appears. One question: *“Did you do it?”* Three taps: yes / partial / no. One optional line of reflection. The Forge reads the day, updates the Life Log, adjusts tomorrow’s Play priors. The fire updates. You sleep.

SUNDAY REVIEW — THE FORGE SPEAKS

Sundays, 5 minutes. The Forge speaks. Three sections, one screen:

HERE’S WHAT GREW · The plays you tended, the days the fire was bright, the patterns that held. Specific. Honest. “You tended Calculus 4 of 7 days. That’s who you are now.”

HERE’S WHAT WITHERED · The plays you skipped, the days the fire dimmed, the patterns that broke. Specific, not shaming. “You skipped Thursday again — 6 weeks running. The Forge

sees it.”

HERE’S THE PATTERN I SEE · One or two causal observations, only when confidence is high. “When you sleep under 6h, you skip the next day 78% of the time. Sleep is the lever.”

You read. You plant one intention for next week (one sentence, not a list). The Forge takes it. 90 seconds. Done.

§ 11 · UNDER THE SURFACE

Architecture — Five Layers

Five layers, one app. The top renders, the middle remembers, the lower watches and computes, the bottom guarantees. Each layer has one job. The boundaries are strict.



THE FIVE LAYERS

THE FLAME · UI · Jetpack Compose · The fire ring, the Play, journaling surfaces (write/voice/draw), the Life Log browser. Pure UI, no business logic. Reads from the Ember, never writes directly.

THE EMBER · ObjectBox 4.0 with HNSW vector index. Every action, journal entry, drift event, play outcome is an ember — logged, embedded, retrievable. The single source of truth. SQLCipher encryption at rest.

THE WATCHER · Android system APIs. UsageStatsManager (foreground events), Foreground Service (persistent notification), NotificationListenerService (notification source tracking), AccessibilityService (optional, for drift context — YouTube title reading). Reports events to the Ember, never owns truth.

THE FORGE · On-device intelligence. Gemma 3 1B (router, 529MB int4), Qwen 0.6B (JSON tools), Gemini Nano (fast path if available). RAG over embers via ObjectBox HNSW. Computes: Fire state, daily Play, patterns, predictions, causal chains, drift classification, photo proof verification.

THE BEDROCK · Three invariants, enforced at the compiler and test level. (1) Every tap survives process death. (2) The fire is honest — evidence grades on every claim. (3) You own your embers — full Markdown export anytime, no account, no cloud.

THE STACK

Android production: Kotlin 2.x + Jetpack Compose · Material 3 · ObjectBox 4.0 (with HNSW) · MediaPipe LLM Inference API (Gemma 3 1B) · Hilt · WorkManager + Foreground Service · AccessibilityService · SQLCipher · minSdk 29 · targetSdk 35.

Web prototype (proof of concept): Next.js 16 + TypeScript · Tailwind 4 + shadcn/ui · IndexedDB (simulated Watcher, since web cannot access real UsageStats) · deterministic Forge (no Gemma in browser, but the contract is identical so the swap is trivial).

§ 12 · THE LOOK AND THE GROWTH

Aesthetic + The Fire’s Growth Animation

AESTHETIC — QUIET LUXURY + APPLE + MATERIAL 3 + FIRE

Warm cream paper background (#FAF6EE). Deep ink text (#0A0A0A). Single signal accent: deep amber (#C25A1F) for the fire. Secondary warm: ember orange (#E8893A) and warm umber (#8B5A2B). No pure white, no pure black except the deepest ink. No gradients except the fire itself.

Type: SF Pro Display for large headings (tight tracking, confident weight). Inter for body (clean, friendly, readable). JetBrains Mono for numbers and timestamps. Material 3 tonal surfaces, rounded corners (16–24px), soft elevation. Generous whitespace. The fire is the only ornament.

Motion: playful, springy, jumpy — but never decorative. The fire ring bounces open when tapped. The Play snaps in with an overshoot. The fire’s glow pulses with a 4-second breathe. Framer-motion springs (or Compose springs on Android), never linear easing. Reduced-motion fully honored.

THE FIRE’S GROWTH ANIMATION — NEVER ENDING

The fire is not a static element. It is a procedural animation that grows over the user’s lifetime of use. This is the most ambitious visual engineering in the app, and the most original.

Day-by-day: The flame tongues refine. Subtle particle effects (floating embers) increase in density as the fire brightens. Color shifts from warm umber (low) to bright amber (Blazing) to a soft gold halo (Gorgeous).

Week-by-week: New visual elements appear at milestones. Week 2: a second flame tongue. Week 4: a halo. Week 8: embers floating up. Each milestone is tied to a real behavioral threshold (e.g., 4 of 7 days tended for 4 weeks = halo), not a cosmetic timer.

Month-by-month: The fire’s base widens. The fire grows from a single flame to a small hearth. Stages: Spark (day 1) → Flame (week 1) → Hearth (month 1) → Forge (month 3) → Constellation (year 1). Each stage is rendered procedurally from the user’s actual fire state, not hand-animated.

Year-by-year: Entirely new stages unlock. The fire becomes a constellation (year 1), then a galaxy (year 2), then — and this is the long arc — the visual metaphor itself evolves. The user who has used BU for 3 years sees something nobody in year 1 sees. The animation system is designed to grow indefinitely, like Egg, Inc.

WHY PROCEDURAL, NOT HAND-ANIMATED

Hand-animating 50 stages is infeasible for one developer at 2 hours a day. Procedural fire (particle system + parametric flame tongues + milestone-driven state changes) means one system renders infinite stages. The engineering is harder up front (build the procedural system once) but the long-tail cost is zero. This is the only path to “never ending” for a solo project.

§ 13 · THE MOAT AND THE BUILD

Originality · Build Plan · The GitHub Repository

ORIGINALITY — WHY THIS IS NOT ANOTHER HABIT APP

I will not pretend the fire is novel as a skin. Forest, Finch, Habitica all use fire-adjacent metaphors. The defensible novelty is the combination, and the moat is the architecture decision itself:

Two-tier with model-download-as-commitment. No free app does this. The model download is a deliberate opt-in moment, not silent bloat. Users who do not care stay in Lite and leave. The product is for people who want to be watched.

The fire as functional state, not decoration. When the fire is low, the app dims — its intelligence goes quiet, surfaces less, withholds value. Nobody does this because inverting engagement is bad business — unless your business is the user's actual discipline.

On-device AI at the system level. Gemma 3 1B + ObjectBox + RAG over your own behavior. No cloud. No account. No data leaves the device. The unit economics do not work for free apps, which is why no free app does it. The architecture is the moat.

Smart-context intervention. AccessibilityService reads the YouTube title, Gemma classifies educational vs not, user confirms. No blocker app does this — they all block blindly. The educational exception requires on-device AI, which requires the architecture.

The Life Log (auto + manual). No app combines system-level auto-capture with user-authored manual entries into one timeline. Day One is manual only. Screen Time is auto only. BU is both, with evidence grades preserved.

Multi-year growth animation. Procedural fire that grows indefinitely, tied to real behavioral milestones. Egg, Inc does this for a game. Nobody does it for real life.

Evidence grades on every claim. Observed vs inferred vs user-confirmed vs outcome-confirmed, preserved on every entry. Research-grade provenance in a consumer app. No competitor does this.

THE BUILD PLAN — FOUR PHASES, ONE YEAR

Honest timeline at 2 hours a day, solo, learning as you go. Each phase ends with a thing you actually use on your phone. No phase starts until the previous one is approved by you.

P0 · SPARK · 4 weeks

Contents. BU Lite: planning + journaling (write only) + manual fire tending. Compose UI, ObjectBox schema, fire ring (static state, no growth yet). Ship to your phone. Use it daily.

Exit criterion. You plan tomorrow, write a play, journal, mark it done. The fire is dim (no Watcher yet) but the planning surface works.

P1 · EMBER · 6 weeks

Contents. BU Full opt-in: model download flow, Watcher v1 (UsageStats + FGS, no Accessibility yet), Forge v1 (Fire state computation, daily Play choice via Gemma 3 1B). Life Log auto-capture.

Exit criterion. You opt in. The model downloads. The Watcher runs. The fire is honest for the first time. The Play is computed, not written.

P2 · FLAME · 8 weeks

Contents. Intervention ladder (3-stage escalation, no smart context yet). Hard Focus mode (whitelist). Voice journaling (Whisper-tiny). Photo proof v1 (MobileNet embedding, no anti-cheat yet). Manual off-phone Life Log entries.

Exit criterion. Drift triggers the ladder. Hard Focus blocks apps. You can voice-journal and photo-prove. The Life Log fills both auto and manual.

P3 · FORGE · 12 weeks

Contents. AccessibilityService for YouTube title reading + Gemma educational classification (smart context). Free-draw canvas (Excalidraw-style). Causal chain detection. Prediction surfacing. The Gorgeous state + first growth animation milestones.

Exit criterion. Smart context works. The canvas works. The Forge surfaces patterns and predictions. The fire can reach Gorgeous after 30 honest days. The growth animation begins.

P4 · CONSTELLATION · ongoing

Contents. Multi-year growth animation system (procedural fire + milestone-driven stages). Year-arc data model. Performance hardening. Backup/restore. Desktop reader (read-only, Markdown). The long arc.

Exit criterion. The fire grows over years. New stages unlock. The app is a 10-year companion.

THE GITHUB REPOSITORY

Public from day one. Versioned. Memory folder for any LLM. The structure:

```
bu-app/ ├── README.md # Living summary. What BU is. Where we are. ├── PLAN.md # Current locked plan (this doc, v6). Supersedes all prior. ├── PROGRESS.md # Append-only log: what was done, when, what's next. ├── MEMORY/ # For any LLM (Claude, GPT, Cursor) reading the repo │ ├── context.md # "You are reading BU's repo. Here's what you need to know." │ ├── decisions.md # Every architectural decision, with rationale and date. │ ├── glossary.md # Vocabulary: Fire, Forge, Watcher, Ember, Play, etc. │ └── lessons-learned.md # What failed, what worked, what surprised us. ├── research/ # All research, versioned │ ├── v1-archive/ v2-archive/ v3-archive/ v4-archive/ │ ├── v5-garden/ v6-fire/ │ └── (each version preserved as history) ├── docs/ # User-facing docs (when shipped) ├── src/ # Android app (Kotlin + Compose) │ ├── app/ flame/ ember/ watcher/ forge/ bedrock/ ├── native/ # JNI bridges, model hosting ├── experiments/ # Spike code (Gemma latency, Accessibility POC) ├── assets/ # Fire animation stages, model files (git-lfs) └── .github/workflows/ # CI: build APK, run tests,
```

```
lint
```

The **MEMORY/** folder is the key invention — it means any future LLM session (you, me, Cursor, Claude) can read the repo and pick up where the last session left off. This is how you build a year-long project with AI assistance without losing context. Every session reads MEMORY/ first, then PROGRESS.md, then PLAN.md. The LLM never starts cold.

§ 14 · THE ROAD AHEAD

What’s Next

Three horizons. The first is now. The second is the year. The third is the long arc.

NOW — THIS RUN

This document. The v6 vision, locked. Next: I will help you initialize the GitHub repository with the structure above — README, PLAN.md (this doc), PROGRESS.md, MEMORY/ folder with the four starter files, research/v6-fire/ with this PDF and supporting research. The repository becomes the source of truth. Every future session starts there.

NEXT — THE YEAR

P0 Spark (4 weeks): BU Lite on your Galaxy A54. Planning, journaling, manual fire. You use it daily and tell me what breaks. P1 Ember (6 weeks): the Watcher activates, the fire becomes honest, the Play is computed. P2 Flame (8 weeks): intervention, hard focus, voice journaling, photo proof, manual Life Log. P3 Forge (12 weeks): smart context, free-draw canvas, causal chains, prediction, the Gorgeous state. End of year one: BU Full v1 in your pocket, offline, on-device, honest.

LONG ARC — THE CONSTELLATION

Year two and beyond: the multi-year growth animation, desktop reader, backup/restore, the long-tail features. The fire keeps growing. New stages unlock. The app becomes a 10-year companion — a complete record of your life, a discipline engine that learned you, a fire you kept lit. The promise is small and total: BU watches you honestly, remembers everything, speaks the truth, and never leaves you and never locks you in. The fire is the discipline. The Forge is the brain. The Watcher is the eyes. The Bedrock is the guarantee. You are the spark.

> *“Open the app. See the fire. Tap it. Get the one play that matters. Go do it. The fire grows. Drift, and the fire dims. The app goes dark. You want it back — tend it. Become a little more like the person you said you would be — today, and again tomorrow, and for the years after that. The fire is alive. Keep it lit.”*

— END OF VISION. Next artifact: the GitHub repository, initialized.

APPENDIX

Concept Lineage — v4 → v5 → v6

Every named concept from v4 and v5, and its fate in v6. The lineage shows what survived three rethinks and what each version killed.

Concept	v4	v5 (garden)	v6 (fire)
Central metaphor	Personal Life OS (BTK kernel)	Garden (living organism)	Fire (discipline as functional state)
Front surface	5-tab LOOM IA	Bloom screen + Garden overlay	Fire ring + one-sentence Play
Daily commitment	Big Three / Main Front / Minimum Day	The single Bloom	The single Play (Forge-computed in Full)
Planning	Dusk Close 6-min contract	Evening Close 60-sec	Evening Close 60-sec + Lite manual planning
Sunday review	Week Compass 15-min	Season Turn 5-min	Forge Speaks 90-sec
Behaviour engine	Adaptive Firmness Ladder L0–L5	Keeper one-breath	Intervention ladder 3-stage + smart context
Drift intervention	Contract Lock + ceilings	One-breath friction	Nudge → aggressive → overlay+block + YT smart-conte
AI role	Needle 3, Phase 6 (late)	Needle 3 as Voice (optional)	Gemma 3 1B as Forge (core, but opt-in via model downlo
Memory	30-table SQLite + embeddings	Soil (auto + Stones)	Ember (ObjectBox + HNSW) + Life Log (auto + manual)
Journaling	JournalRecord extraction	Stones (deliberate memory)	Three surfaces: write / voice / free-draw canvas
Object taxonomy	Track / Spark / Block / Care Item	Plant / Bird / Stone / Stream / Wildflower / Season	Flame + Ember (no kind taxonomy — the Forge chooses)
Architecture planes	BTK 5 planes	3 layers (Bloom / Soil / Root)	5 layers (Flame / Ember / Watcher / Forge / Bedrock)
Engineering invariants	12 (I1–I12)	3 (tap survives / garden never lies / you own soil)	3 (tap survives / fire honest / you own embers)
Build phases	8 (P0–P7)	4 (Seed / Soil / Garden / Voice), 7 weeks	4 (Spark / Ember / Flame / Forge) + P4 ongoing, ~1 year
Two-tier product	No (monolithic)	No (single tier)	Yes — Lite (no model) + Full (model + Watcher)
System-level watching	UsageStats planned	Not in v5	Full power: FGS + UsageStats + NotificationListener + A
Life Log	Not in v4	Not in v5	Auto phone activity + manual off-phone entries
Photo proof	Not in v4	Not in v5	MobileNet v3 embedding, anti-cheat via novelty check
Multi-year growth	Not in v4	Not in v5	Procedural fire, never-ending, Egg-Inc-style
Public repo + LLM memory	Not in v4	Not in v5	Yes — GitHub with MEMORY/ folder
Mindful feature parity (blocking)	Phase 2	Out of v1	Out of v1 (BU is companion + blocker hybrid, not Mindfu
Evidence grades	5 grades (SCHEDULED → OUTCOME_C	Preserved	Preserved (4 grades: OBSERVED / INFERRED / USER_
Reality Multiplier	Yes, shown to user	Silent, behind chooser	Silent, behind Forge prediction
Offline-first	Yes	Yes	Yes — model on-device, no cloud, no account

Concept	v4	v5 (garden)	v6 (fire)
Markdown export	Yes	Yes	Yes — full Life Log + embers + journal entries

Net: v6 preserves the v4 evidence-grade system, the offline-first principle, the reality multiplier, and the Markdown export promise. It kills v4's enterprise architecture (BTK 5 planes, 12 invariants, 30 tables, 8 phases), v5's garden metaphor and kind taxonomy, and v5's single-tier model. It adds: the fire as functional state, two-tier Lite/Full, system-level Watcher, on-device Forge (Gemma 3 1B + ObjectBox), three-surface journaling, the Life Log (auto + manual), photo proof, multi-year growth animation, and the public GitHub repo with LLM memory.